

They look like earnest young students, clean-shaven, educated, well-dressed, soft-spoken, almost the boys next door. Saquib Nisar, Zia-ur Rehman and Shakeel are all in their early 20s. After they were picked by the police from Zakir Nagar, a common friend of the trio facilitated two meetings with them, at the Zakir Nagar police station and later during the press conference called by the South District police to announce their arrest. These meetings resulted in a frank discussion, scary in terms of the twisted ideology as well as the hatred and desire for revenge that underlines everything they say. More alarming is the matter-of-fact way in which they describe their acts of horrific terror and widespread death and destruction. What is more frightening

bony, fair, not more than 5'5" tall, and wears an expression of utter disgust on his face, suspicion too, but at the same time, does not seem to care the least about his fate or the fact that he committed mass murder just a week earlier.

His sharp, wide eyes are partially open; hooded, impossible to penetrate. He wears black trousers and an oversized, light shirt that hangs below his waist. His tone is abrasive and he has an unfriendly vibe about him. Yet, when he starts speaking, cold chills run down my spine. "You planted the bombs?" I ask. "Yes," he says, forcing his eyes open. "Your friend, Nisar, feels that he was taken for a ride by Atif in the name of Allah," I introspect as he leans forward, as if not wanting his family to hear his words. "Whatever

ZIA-UR REHMAN



“Whatever knowledge I have about Islam, I have no regrets about what I did.”

“My father told me I’m not his son. He doesn’t understand jihad for Allah, and nothing else matters to me.”

“I have no regrets about what I did, and the way I did it. Ask them to shoot me for this.”

is that they could be young men you meet in a local Barista café or see working on their laptops at a cyber café. Up close and personal, they turn into something malevolent, walking bombs who perform their act of mass slaughter in the name of Allah and without the slightest suggestion of remorse. Behind their endearing looks hides an enduring sense of being wronged. This has clouded every faculty of their intellect and reduced them to willing instruments of the invisible puppeteers of terror.

■ Zia-ur Rehman, 24

A third year student at Jamia Millia Islamia, accused of planting bombs at Connaught Place and Ahmedabad and providing logistical support.

Zia-ur Rehman is sitting with his father, who had also been arrested for forging the rent documents of L-18, Batla House, the infamous flat where the terror module led by Atif lived. The thick chain attached to Rehman’s hand is a complete contrast to his frail frame. He is small, thin,

knowledge I have about Islam and what I understand about how things work in this world, I have no regrets about what I did,” he whispers. “So, if you had not got arrested, you would have gone on to plant the bombs at Nehru Place as per the plan?” “Yes,” he replies without hesitation. His small frame becomes rigid, the nerves on his frail forearm tense. “It is a jihad, it’s a war,” he declares. This is followed by my next query—“Who is your enemy?” Rehman parrots without emotion, “This is jihad for Allah, only the privileged get to do it.” It is only then that I ask him, “But who is your jihad for Allah against?” He tries to find words to describe his enemy. His concept of an adversary seems amorously lost in the deep-rooted sense of insult he feels at belonging to a certain religion. He says, hesitantly, “It is against Maharashtra for ignoring the Srikrishna Report; it is against what happened in Gujarat.”

But how would killing people, say in Karol Bagh in Delhi, help target those responsible for say Maharashtra or Gujarat? The question